



# Speaking Freedom: Resistance through language, art and culture

Exploring Resistance in South Africa and beyond

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# THE ROAD TO FREEDOM

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# Global Patterns of Oppression

## Liberia

- Living Liberia Fabric (Harell) captures how storytelling stitches together **trauma** and **hope** after generational violence

## Haiti

- Historical erasure and language are tools of oppression used by those in power in both Haiti and Palestine (DeGraff)
- Speaking Kreyòl is an act of reclaiming dignity

## Palestine

- forced assimilation into Hebrew culture mirrors the struggle for cultural survival
- Those seeking freedom and autonomy are demonized by western world (Sansour and Degraff)

## Themes

- language and cultural expression are central to both oppression and resistance
- Resistance, then, is not just fighting battles — it's speaking, singing, writing, performing, and remembering in the face of silence.

# READINGS IN BRIEF

## Honoring Your Native Language

- Taught that native language is broken French
- Great loss in not keeping ancestral language alive
- Palestine similar in needing to understand Hebrew and assimilate to Israeli culture

### Liberia Living Fabric

- generational violence
- Liberians navigating/narrating their experiences after civil war
- Piecing fabric together
- Education and moving past colonial past

## Writing Revolutions

- Language is a weapon used by those in power in Haiti and Palestine
- Historical erasure is a key element of colonial oppression

### Every Person is a Person

- Violence in places where people refuse to be dominated
- Demonized for seeking freedom and autonomy
- Pain created by US and western world, or at least not improved
- "Peacekeepers" who don't speak language

## Connecting the readings together

**"Palestinians and Haitians are abused and abandoned siblings whose subjugation is born in a womb of pain and resistance."** - Every person is a person

- Gangs in Haiti and Israelis in Palestine armed by US
- Violence perpetuated in Liberia due to colonial past
- Haiti revolution is a model for black and global liberation: multilingual, pan-african, collective

Can you think of a specific group today that, like Haitians and Palestinians, faces violence or instability rooted in Western intervention or abandonment? For example, Indigenous communities in the U.S. and Canada, or Congolese people affected by mining industries.

**Compare:** How do language, culture, or media play a role in their struggles for self-determination?



## Connecting the readings together

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- Gangs in Haiti and Israelis in Palestine
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- Haiti revolution is a model for black and global liberation: multilingual, pan-african, collective

Can you think of any other peoples that are similarly being oppressed by the western world? Compare and contrast them with Haiti and Palestine



# SOUTH AFRICA HISTORICAL CONTEXT

- Colonized first by the Dutch (1652), then by the British (1806)
- Apartheid era (1948-1994) denied black south africans the right to vote, citizenship, freedom of movement, access to quality education and land
- White landowning minority exploiting African majority
- Colonial economy built on land dispossession, forced labor, and racial segregation
- Homelands (Bantustans) created to forcibly relocate black south africans



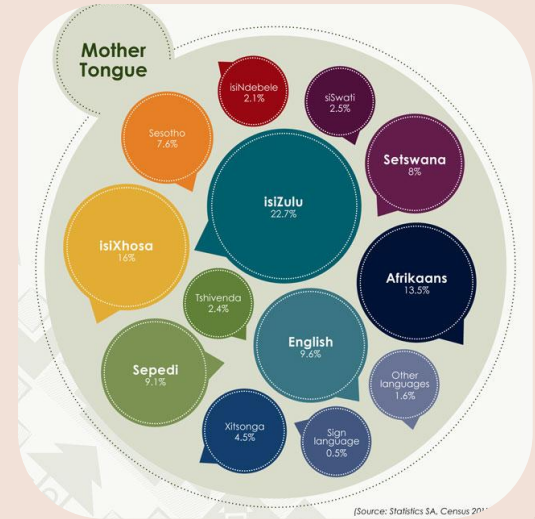
# The Tools of Oppression: Classification

- Rigid class system: white, Bantu (black), colored, asian
- "Race categories were treated as natural but were constantly renegotiated through violent legal, scientific, and cultural performances." - Bowker
- Bureaucratic language labeled people, but people's identities refused to fit neatly in these boxes
- The act of categorizing human beings by race is itself a performance of domination, just as performance art or linguistic rebellion can be performances of resistance.



# Honoring Native Language

- Colonization in waves:
  - Dutch
  - English
- Effect on education, government, and commerce
- Oppression through intentional linguistic barriers
- Recent changes and developments
- How do you think official national languages and the usage of language as a power of oppression is seen today?
- What similarities do you see here between the usage of language in oppression between Haiti and South Africa? What problems do you see with these practices?



## Living Fabric: Media



# Living Fabric

- “Broken Chord” performance
- Inspired by the African Choir (1890s)
- Focus on the usage of performance art and this specific talent to tell their story, on issues of colonization, race, and colliding cultures
- What value do you see in using performance art (or art in general) to tell a rich cultural history as is portrayed here?
- How have you seen performance art used in similar ways?



# Every Person is a Person

- South Africa shares struggles against colonial and racial discrimination
- Similar in land dispossession, state-backed racial hierarchy, punishing authors for resisting white rule
- Global complicity/silence and western backing, similar to US supporting Israeli military and intervening in Haiti
- Freedom struggle expressed through art, music, storytelling, and education (like Palestinian poetry and Haitian language)
- Recognized Palestinian genocide and use legal language to resist domination (ICJ)



# South Africa Today

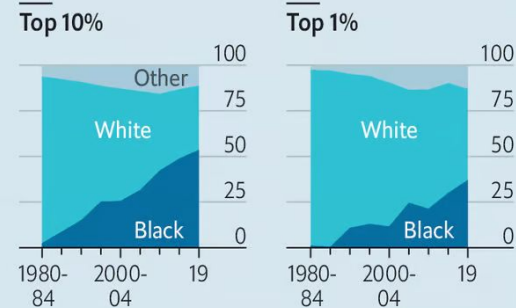
- Still disproportionate amount of wealth owned by white South Africans vs black south africans
- Still very segregated housing between rich suburbs and poor slums
- Underfunded schools in black townships
- Again “liberation without justice” still many systemic issues despite political equality



## Big changes—at the top

1

South Africa, share of black and white earners  
By income group\*, % of total



\*Five-year average. 2019 single year

Source: "Inequality, Redistribution, and Growth: Evidence from South Africa, 1993-2019", Gethin et al., 2021

# Debate

Performance art was more powerful than traditional forms of protest in the struggle against apartheid.

Things to think about (this will be hidden)

- Protests viewed as criminalizing and threatening
- Performance art humanizes the struggle
- Expresses more personal ideas
- Direct protests lead to more immediate tangible change
- Performance arts have little research inside south africa



# Conclusion

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